

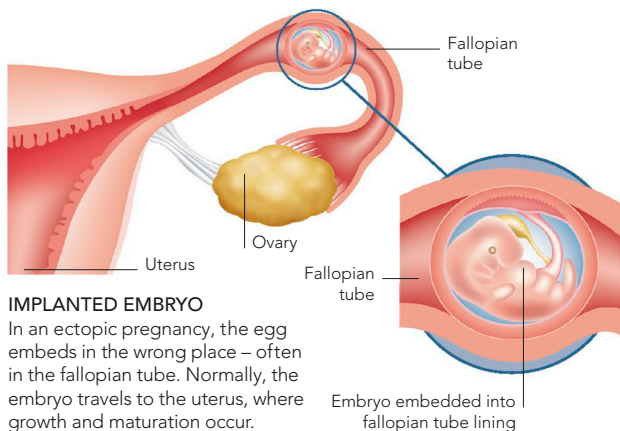
PREGNANCY AND LABOUR DISORDERS

PROBLEMS CAN ARISE IN NORMALLY HEALTHY WOMEN DURING PREGNANCY AND LABOUR, WHICH MAY ENDANGER BOTH THE MOTHER'S AND THE BABY'S HEALTH. FEW DISORDERS OF PREGNANCY AND LABOUR HAVE ANY PERMANENT PHYSICAL EFFECT ON EITHER MOTHER OR BABY.

ECTOPIC PREGNANCY

About 1 per cent of pregnancies are ectopic; they are more common in women under the age of 30.

The fertilized egg does not implant in the uterine lining, which is the normal place, but develops in one of the fallopian tubes, or more rarely in another area altogether. The embryo does not develop normally, and so the pregnancy usually fails. The embryo must be surgically removed to avoid rupture of the fallopian tube and to prevent internal bleeding.

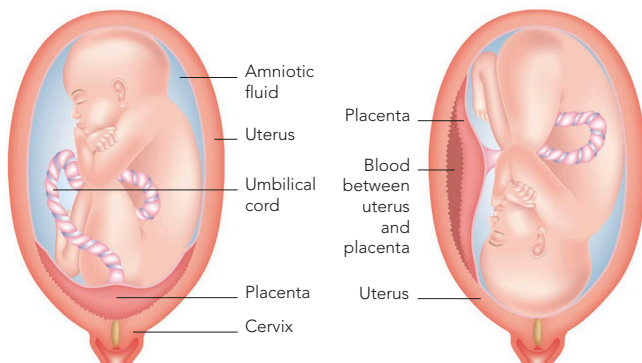


IMPLANTED EMBRYO

In an ectopic pregnancy, the egg embeds in the wrong place – often in the fallopian tube. Normally, the embryo travels to the uterus, where growth and maturation occur.

PLACENTAL PROBLEMS

Two main problems can affect the placenta: placenta praevia, in which the placenta covers the opening to the cervix; and placental abruption, in which the placenta separates from the uterine wall. The degree of severity in placenta praevia depends on how much of the cervix is covered. If completely covered, the condition is serious. Placental abruption usually comes on suddenly, and can threaten the fetus as essential blood supplies are compromised. Both conditions can cause vaginal bleeding, but in less severe cases, symptoms may go unnoticed.



PLACENTA PRAEVIA

In complete placenta praevia, as shown here, the placenta entirely covers the cervix. In a less severe form, the placenta only partially obstructs the exit from the uterus.

PLACENTAL ABRUPTION

Premature separation of the placenta from the uterus may be concealed, as shown here, in which case blood collects between the uterus and placenta.